

RIZWAN ZAFAR

PAYMENTS PRODUCT AND PROGRAM EXECUTIVE | FINTECH INFRASTRUCTURE | EMERGING AND FRONTIER MARKETS

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Chief Product Officer with 17 years building and scaling payment gateway, cross-border and merchant-acquiring products across emerging and frontier markets. At Simpaisa, scaled the leading payment-gateway connector for frontier markets from market entry to \$1B+ annual GTV, ~270M annual transactions and 150+ merchants across 5 markets. Owns the end-to-end product stack (pay-in, payouts and cross-border) plus the program and PMO discipline that delivers it: multi-squad execution, SteerCo governance and vendor management. Built a product controls environment from scratch (PCI-DSS Level 1 and ISO 27001), audited without findings across 5 regulatory jurisdictions. Local infrastructure partner for DLocal, Thunes, Boku, Coda Payments and Tazapay, enabling global platforms (TikTok/ByteDance, Samsung, Shein, Codashop, Xsolla, Uber, MoneyGram) to land in markets where they have no local rails.

IMPACT SNAPSHOT

\$1B+	270M+	5	150+
ANNUAL GTV	PAYMENTS / YEAR	LIVE MARKETS	MERCHANTS

CORE COMPETENCIES

GATEWAY AND ORCHESTRATION	Payment gateway orchestration pay-in payouts cross-border settlement reconciliation multi-currency and FX dynamic corridor pricing
MERCHANT AND ACQUIRING	Merchant acquiring merchant onboarding (weeks to hours) self-service flows automated KYC/KYB risk-based approval blended and IC++ pricing merchant of record
PAYMENT METHODS AND RAILS	Card acquiring (MPGS/MDES) tokenization 3DS2 mobile wallets DCB IBFT QR bill payments BNPL open banking stablecoin settlement
RISK, COMPLIANCE AND SECURITY	PCI-DSS Level 1 ISO 27001 AML and CFT fraud prevention chargeback management multi-jurisdiction regulatory readiness EMI operations
PRODUCT AND PROGRAM LEADERSHIP	Product strategy and roadmap P&L ownership business cases GTM PMO governance SteerCo OKRs vendor management org design (2 to 8 PMs)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Chief Product Officer (and acting CTO, 2024) | Simpaisa

Dubai, UAE | Aug 2020 - Present

- Defined and own the multi-year product strategy and roadmap with the CEO and C-suite across pay-in, payout and cross-border product lines; scaled from market entry to \$1B+ annual GTV across 5 jurisdictions.
- Own the end-to-end pay-in stack (card acquiring MPGS/MDES, mobile wallets, DCB, IBFT, vouchers, bill payments, QR and tokenization) and the payout stack: switch integration, direct wallet payouts, cash-out and B2B vendor disbursements.
- Drove authorization optimization across issuers and acquirers via smart-retry orchestration and token-failure remediation, holding 90% straight-through processing with 99.9% platform uptime.
- Designed merchant onboarding end-to-end (self-service flows, automated KYC/KYB, tiered risk-based approval, dynamic pricing by category), cutting onboarding from weeks to hours across 150+ merchants.
- Built fraud prevention, chargeback management and AML/CFT infrastructure; held fraud losses below 0.1% of GTV across 5 markets.
- Led PCI-DSS Level 1 and ISO 27001 certification programs from scratch, both audited without findings across 5 regulatory jurisdictions.
- Scaled the partnership ecosystem as the local infrastructure layer for DLocal, Thunes, Boku, Coda Payments, Tazapay and Eastnets; established blended and IC++ pricing for enterprise merchants.
- Shipped 4 product launches in 2024 on time and within budget during a regulatory transition, while serving as dual CPO and acting CTO.
- Built and led the product organization from 2 to 8 product managers; chaired weekly steering committees with internal leads and external partners; reported product KPIs (approval rates, GTV, fraud rate, SLA) to the CEO and board monthly.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE, CONTINUED

Project Manager, Payments Operations | Daraz (Alibaba Group)

Karachi, Pakistan | Mar 2020 - Aug 2020

- Ran payments operations and product readiness across 5 markets (Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Myanmar) during the COVID-driven transaction surge; lifted checkout conversion 15%.
- Coordinated multi-country reconciliation, payment compliance, fraud-rule tightening and vendor management at Alibaba scale; cut false declines 20% through 3DS2 policy tuning.

Head of Product & Projects | Tapmad (OTT streaming)

Karachi, Pakistan | Jul 2017 - Mar 2020

- Owned product strategy and monetization for Pakistan's leading OTT platform; designed and launched direct carrier billing with all four major telcos, scaling from 0 to 5M+ paid subscribers in under three years.
- Identified unsustainable unit economics and led the full migration to wallet and card billing; payment cost cut from ~50% to ~1%, ARPU up 70% through pricing and bundle optimization.

EARLIER PROGRAM AND PMO LEADERSHIP

PMO and Project Manager | Wing Logic

Dubai, UAE | Apr 2017 - Oct 2017

- Established PMO governance, portfolio reporting, risk tracking and executive cadence for a multi-project technology and engineering portfolio.

Assistant Manager, Projects | CIMKO / Nyumba Ya Akiba

DR Congo | May 2016 - Jan 2017

- Managed ERP and IT infrastructure initiatives in a greenfield industrial environment, coordinating vendors, procurement, schedule and operational handover.

Project Manager, PMO | DS Engineering Services

Karachi, Pakistan | Sep 2012 - Feb 2016

- Managed engineering-project portfolios and built reporting, controls and delivery governance across \$8M to \$15M utilities and infrastructure programs; PMO governance and reporting cut delays and improved delivery efficiency up to 70%.

Senior Planning Engineer | PESCO

Karachi, Pakistan | Jun 2009 - Aug 2012

- Planned and monitored power-infrastructure work, establishing the reliability and operational discipline that later shaped fintech product leadership.

RECOGNITION AND PROFESSIONAL LEADERSHIP

Youngest Project Manager of the Year - PMI Karachi (2015) | Vice President (2022-23) and Director, Governance (2021-22) - PMI Karachi Chapter

EDUCATION

MIT Sloan School of Management - Executive Program, Mastering Design Thinking (2022)

University of Karachi - M.Sc. Applied Physics (2009-2012); B.Sc. Physics, Statistics & Mathematics (2007-2009)

CERTIFICATIONS

Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO), Scrum Alliance (2024) | Certified ScrumMaster (CSM), Scrum Alliance (2024) | Project Management Professional (PMP), PMI (2016) | PMI Agile Certified Practitioner (PMI-ACP), PMI (2021) | COBIT 5 Foundation, ISACA (2019) | ITIL v3 Foundation, AXELOS (2018)

SELECTED PROFESSIONAL FOCUS

VP, Head or Director of Product, payments infrastructure. Product leadership for payment networks, PSPs, acquiring, cross-border and regulated fintech. Program and transformation leadership where product, controls, partners and delivery must operate as one system.

PORTFOLIO AND CONTACT

Selected work and payments writing: rzifi.com

Book a 15-minute introduction: cal.com/rizwan-zafar-gws2uk/15min